



ON THE SIDELINES

By Jim Ogle

A pot of gold for Monroe

DETROIT—It has been said that you can find anything in a cafeteria, but it is doubtful if anyone ever found a pot o' gold in one as did Zack Monroe, one of the newer Yankees, last Sunday night in Indianapolis.

"We had played a doubleheader in Charleston," Zack says, "then jumped right to Indianapolis. About midnight I was sitting in a cafeteria reading the local papers, naturally concentrating on the sports pages. There was a story listing all the trades that had been made that day. As I got to the last paragraph, I thought I was reading what I wanted to read rather than what I saw.

"It said that the Yankees had recalled me from Denver," Zack said. "I hadn't heard about it and didn't know whether to believe it or not. About 2 o'clock in the morning Andy Cohen, our manager, called me to ask me if I had heard anything about the item in the paper. He knew nothing about it either.

"In the morning all the fellows were asking me when I was leaving and wouldn't believe me when I told them I had heard nothing," Zack continued. "Finally about noon, however, I got official confirmation and was told to report in Cleveland. It seemed as if I had found the pot o' gold and it sure was a big thrill."

Monroe is not a kid as he gets his first chance with the Yankees. He is 26 years old. He was signed out of Bradley University in 1952 by Lou Magullo and broke in with Quiney where he had a 7-6 record. He was called into service right after that and didn't return to baseball until 1955 with Binghamton.

"I had a 2-4 record and was having trouble getting anybody out," Zack recalls. "I had just about become convinced that I didn't have it and was ready to go home and finish my college education, when I won my next six games and the baseball bug had really bitten me. I knew that I had to take the full shot at it and now, at last, here I am."

The Yanks get a 'new barber'

Monroe had impressed Casey Stengel during spring training and, when he sent him back to Denver, Stengel practically predicted that Zack would be back before mid-season. "That boy looked good to me," Stengel said. "I have too many pitchers I have to give a shot and if I kept Monroe he would waste his time on the bench. Now he is at Denver, can keep pitching and if I need him he will be ready."

Oddly enough Monroe has come up to replace The Barber, Sal Maglie, and certainly has the training to step up to the barber's chair. Zack's father runs a barber college back in Peoria, Ill., his home town. Zack has spent most of the winters helping his father, who is also overseer of the poor in Peoria and hence away from his office a great deal.

"I never finished the barber course," Zack explains. "I have done a lot of teaching of fundamentals, however. I help teach the new student how to hone a razor, use the tools and things like that. Actually I trained to be a physical education teacher and finally got my degree, but most of my teaching has been in barber college."

Oddly enough, Monroe is out of the Maglie mold as a pitcher, too. He doesn't have overpowering stuff, but moves the ball around, has pinpoint control (69 walks in 224 innings last year) and keeps the ball down. Off his record he is easy to hit, but hard to score upon.

Monroe, of course, was happy to answer the Yankee summons but it did involve a few personal problems. Zack is another of those ballplayers who like to live in a trailer, moving his wife and two young daughters around the country in a 41-foot trailer.

"I thought I could take a quick trip to Denver and haul the trailer to Peoria," Monroe says, "but I had to report right away and now my family is in Denver with the trailer. I have to try to get someone to move it to New Jersey where I hope to find a trailer park somewhere around the George Washington Bridge area.

Wife's a veteran too

"My wife was happy to hear the news," Zack says, "but when she found out I couldn't come home and get her she was quite upset. When we finish this trip I will have been on the road 28 days for we were on the ninth day of a road trip with Denver.

"She traveled with me through the lean days of the minors," Zack says, "so it is only fitting that she be with me now that I have reached the only place to play ball—the majors. I certainly hope that I can get arrangements made to get her to Jersey as soon as possible after we get home."

Monroe had a 16-10 mark and was 10-2 when he got the Yankee call.

"I almost made a real mistake this spring," Zack recalls. "I didn't want to go to the rookie school because that meant I lost a month's work and with a family to support that was rough. But the way it worked out, it was the best thing that could have happened.

"I'm not making any predictions about what I can do up here," Monroe says. "I know it is going to be a real test, but I'm ready and at the top of my form. I am confident I can do a job and just hope that I get a chance quickly."

Now the Yanks even have recruits out of barber college available to replace the Old Barber. If Zack can even come close to Maglie, then he'll be around a long time.